Educating the Citizen Professional: Higher Education and Democracy's Future

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Thank you President Hargis for your gracious introduction. I want to express appreciation to Tami Moore, who was a visiting fellow at the Sabo Center for Democracy and Citizenship at Augsburg College last fall. She helped us enormously in preparing to lessons from our youth civic education initiative Public Achievement through a book and other means, doing interviews with many colleagues in Eastern and Central Europe. She also organized my visit to OSU, which has already proven to be highly informative. I want to express thanks to Milad Moheb' ali, a graduate student in Higher Education Administration. Milad has done yeoman background research on the land grant history of OSU and the public work traditions of Oklahoma in preparation for this lecture. Finally, I want to thank the College of Education and OSU for inviting me to give the 2017 Kamm Lecture. I am honored to be here.

Last November, shortly after the election at the University of California Santa Barbara, I recalled Henry James' statement about dangerous times.

> "Evil is insolent and strong; beauty enchanting but rare; goodness very apt to be weak; folly ever apt to be defiant; wickedness to carry the day; imbeciles to be in great places, people of sense in small, and mankind generally unhappy. But the world as it stands is no narrow illusion ... we can neither forget it nor deny it nor dispense with it."

I liked James' realism. And I will later return to the dangers. In my view the polarized, inflamed public culture today is the culmination of long developing trends around the world which feed political conflict and social fragmentation. These trends are fed by many dynamics, including new technologies of polarization which intentionally inflame and deepen divisions. Fragmentation is also tied closely to technocratic practices that have substituted *informational* methods for *relational* approaches in dealing with public problems and our challenges of living together as a very diverse society.

Higher education is not an innocent bystander in this process of fragmentation and division. Research cultures and incentive systems encourage detachment from public life over the last half century. Detachment has influenced professional identities of society's leaders in every field. Professionals have learned to think of themselves as "disciplinary professionals," in the phrasing of intellectual historian Thomas Bender, no longer "civic professionals" whose work is embedded in and contributes to the civic life of communities.

If higher education contributes to social fragmentation and division, colleges and universities also have tremendous opportunities, resources, and responsibilities to take leadership in reversing these trends. In this moment in history, OSU and other colleges stand at the cusp of this great challenge. The idea and practices of citizen professionalism are central to taking leadership.

Plan for today's talk

Today I stress the need to move beyond a polarity which weakens higher education connections with communities and publics, damaging us politically while also diminishing our capacities for civic leadership. This is the tension between preparation for vocation on one hand and liberal education on the other.

Richard Levin's talk at the University of Illinois-Urbana Champaign in 2015 illustrated. In his talk, entitled "Preparing Undergraduates for Global Citizenship." Levin, President Emeritus of Yale, draws extensively on Yale's curricular innovations to revisit "furniture" and "disciplines" of the mind in American higher education. He has important insights. But he neglects anything beyond cognitive development. Specifically he

leaves out the disciplines of *heart* and *hand,* affect and action. Affective education and preparing for work-related disciplines of action have deep roots in the land tradition. In fact, land grant colleges and universities have been leading educational centers for connecting liberal learning to practical education. Education for affect and action are clear in the rich co-curricular, service learning and leadership development efforts at OSU I have heard about since I arrived.

Adding heart and hand involves both recovery and innovation. Here, I offer, as a heuristic for framing "heart," affective commitments, the concept of a democratic connection with other citizens, the philosophy of nonviolence and also the inclusive patriotism I learned in the civil rights movement. This educating for affect sees citizens not by legal status but rather by people's work as co-creators of an open and dynamic society. Such education also schools us in the demanding disciplines of not demonizing, humiliating, or defeating our enemies but understanding where they come from. Such a set of disciplines are engaging and demanding, the opposite of passive.[1] It also recalls a heritage largely forgotten based on the idea that those in higher education are *citizen* scholars and *citizen* educators. Today, the culture of detachment in higher education means that engaged educators partner *with* communities and societies. They do not usually see themselves as part *of* the life of the society.

Adding "hand" involves commitment to integrating liberal arts with vocational and career preparation. We need a new model of "citizen professional" in many fields, building on the evidence which shows connections between citizenship skills as 21st century job skills. This model prepares graduates who understand and engage the world as it is – equipped to understand the norms and cultures of their work. They are also prepared as effective, relational agents of constructive change and innovation, who understand that institutions are dynamic and evolving, and have potential to be sites for civic revitalization and civic life. This means equipping students with capacities to build public relations across differences and to create schools and businesses, congregations and clinics, nonprofits and public agencies that are foundations for civic life. Citizen professionalism speaks to young people's concerns for "jobs that pay and matter." I focus today on the land grant tradition but also want to stress how much education for heart and hand as well as head, combining liberal arts and practical arts, was also central to locally rooted liberal arts colleges.

Today I want to do three things:

1) Recall education for "heart" and "hand" as well as "head." There are many examples from Oklahoma and OSU.
2) Describe technocratic dynamics which feed fragmentation and polarization.
3) Develop elements of citizen professionalism.

I'll briefly conclude with the challenge of professionals undertaking intellectual leadership in bringing our nation back to the great wells of democracy.

A deepened public narrative

In *After Virtue,* the philosopher Alaisdair MacIntyre observed, "I can only answer the question, 'what am I to do?' if I can answer the prior question, 'of what story or stories do I find myself a part."[2] We've largely lost the richness and complexity of the land grant public narrative.

[1] For a treatment of this concept and its roots, in my own experience, in the southern freedom movement, see Harry C. Boyte, "A Challenging Patriotism," *Change: The Magazine of Higher Learning* Vol. 44, No. 4, pp 22-26.
[2] Alasdaire MacIntyre, After Virtue, p. 279.

The dominant narrative is "service to the nation" through scientific innovation, technology transfer and other expert information with cooperative extension as a transmission belt. As R. A. Hodges and S. Dubb put it in *The Road Less Travelled,* "cooperative extension has been a program that supports a system of information transmission from state land-grant colleges and universities to the populace." This narrative is an unabashedly expert view of the land grant mission. It is conveyed by the picture in the Denver airport. People have problems. Higher education has the solutions.

An alternative narrative, what Scott Peters has called the tragic counter-narrative, is about colonization by experts. As Wendell Berry puts it in *The Unsettling of America,*

> "Far from developing and improving the rural home and rural life, the land-grant colleges have blindly followed the drift of virtually the whole population away from home…blindly rationalizing this disorder as 'progress' or 'miraculous development.' At this point one can begin to understand the violence that has been done to the Morrill Act's provision for a 'liberal and practical education.'"[3]

I live part of the year in South Africa. There this tragic counter-narrative has become central to the debates in African higher education. Calls for decolonizing the university and its knowledge regime are banners in student protests.

Peters acknowledges the reality of both technocratic service delivery and colonizing dynamics. He also proposes a much more complex – and hopeful – public narrative that incorporates a story missing from the other two: land grants as deeply involved in the life of communities and the society in ways that build civic agency, collective capacities for public action across lines of difference. In this vision, extension workers are citizen professionals, part of the life of communities, whose work with rural populations integrates public problem solving and capacity development. It is worth recalling how much this vision, animated by the egalitarian principles of the nation's founding documents like the Declaration of Independence and the Preamble to the Constitution, moved the founders of OSU. "We can have anything we want from the insane asylum of the state capitol. What do we take?," asked George Gardenhire, Populist state representative from Payne County, asked a group of farmers and civic leaders. They decided on a land grant college in the territory (statehood was granted in 1907), Grandehire made a deal with others to bring the college to Payne County in exchange for their support to keep the capital at Gutherie.[4] The Populist Party which he helped to lead, according to the Oklahoma Historical Society entry, "effectively portrayed itself as the true inheritor of the egalitarian visions of Jefferson and Lincoln. Populists promoted regulation of businesses, anti-usury legislation, arbitration of labor disputes and homesteads, while championing education for the common people, relief for the destitute and construction of bridges."[5]

It is also helpful to put ourselves imaginatively back into the environment of land grants in the first half of the twentieth century and the larger forces in the society which influenced them. The 1920s and 1930s were the era of the Harlem Renaissance which boldly asserted that African Americans are co-creators of the nation, claiming equality on the basis of their contributions.

Hale Woodruff, Harlem Renaissance artist, "Settlement and Development"

"Through his artistic efforts the Negro is smashing immemorial stereotypes… impressing upon the national mind the conviction that he is an active and

[3] Ho ring a Forgotten Lineage of Democratic Engagement," forthcoming Eatn d: Oxford University Press), pp. 72, 74.
[4] Ea .
[5] Mil ttp://www.okhistory.org/publications/enc/entry.php?entry=PO013 acce

important force in American life… a creator as well as a creature…a contributor to the nation's common cultural store." James Weldon Johnson, 1930

Land grants and the extension service also drew on New Deal programs like the Federal Writers Project and the Treasury Post Office Mural Project, which affirmed the dignity and intelligence of everyday citizens, the value of work, and, sometimes, the struggle for racial, economic and social justice. These themes in Oklahoma evident in the public art projects of the New Deal. Look at this post office mural, for instance.

POST OFFICE MURAL – ANADARKO OK

Scenes of Kiowa Life

Treasury Section of Fine Arts

Started: 1936 Artists: James Auchiah, Stephen Mopope The historic Anadarko post office building houses a massive mural depicting the ceremonial and social life of the Plains American Indians. The Anadarko Post Office was previously also the site of the Kiowa Indian Agency of the Bureau of Indian Affairs "The Deer Hunter."

Finally, the intellectual culture had strong currents of democratic educational philosophy and practices growing from diverse sources like the settlement house tradition of Jane Addams, the Harlem Renaissance, philosophers of education like John Dewey, and Scandinavian folk schools. All impacted land grant schools like OSU.

Dewey described Jane Addams, co-founder of Hull House in Chicago. Her belief in democracy, he said, derived from her "deep feeling that the simple, the 'humble' peoples of the earth are those in whom primitive impulses of friendly affection are the least spoiled, the most spontaneous." [6] Dewey, like Addams, argued that all knowledge – "academic" no less than "practical" – is social and cooperative, the product of an interplay of experience, testing and experiment, observation, reflection, and conversation. All have the capacity to participate in knowledge-creation.

These themes of respect for everyday citizens, the social and cooperative nature of knowledge, and the dangers of detached experts to democracy itself were widely shared. As Andrew Jewett has detailed in his study of democracy, education, and science, Dewey helped lead a broad movement of "scientific democrats" who saw science and its fields as sites for values and practices like cooperative inquiry and testing ideas in practice, relevant for all members of democratic society.[7] Such ideas resonated powerfully in extension and land grants.[8]

Thus, for instance, Liberty Hyde Bailey, dean of the College of Agriculture at Cornell, argued that every aspect of higher education must be infused with a spirit of public work. Bailey was one of the world's leading horticulturalists and he developed many specialties at Cornell. But he believed specialties eroded the vitality of rural life unless they were understood in a larger context, as part of "a great public work," grounded in respect for the farmers and rural communities' agentic capacities. "The farmer," argued Bailey in 1904, 'is a citizen, a member of the commonwealth." Bailey saw the most important focus of extension work as increasing civic

[6] Feuer, Op Sit, p. 556.

[7] Andrew Jewett, *Science, Democracy and the American University* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2011).

[8] See for instance, Scott Peters, *Democracy and Higher Education* (East Lansing: Michigan State University Press, 2010); and *Changing the Story of Higher Education's Public Purpose and Work* Imagining America keynote, 2006 at http://surface.syr.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1015&context=ia

capacities for self-directed action. "The re-direction of any civilization must rest primarily on the people who comprise it, rather than be imposed from persons in other conditions of life."[9]

There were international influences on land grants as well. Mary Mims of Louisiana State University, founder of the "community organization movement" in cooperative extension, travelled through Denmark to study the folk schools pioneered by the 19th century Danish theologian and educational philosopher N.F.S. Grundtvig. Grundtvig birthed the folk school movement which spread across Scandinavia and beyond in the 19th and 20th century. Like popular education in the tradition of Paulo Freire, folk schools draw on popular experiences as texts. They oppose "one directional" instruction, what Freire famously calls "banking" education. Folk schools also seek to democratize unequal power relations. The *primary* focus of folk schools is building popular power and cultural pride and confidence in multidimensional ways not struggle against oppression. Folk schools aim at democratic, empowering love of people's traditions and cultures, an "indigenous, general education…to enable people to understand the structure of our society." They also focus on energizing the democratic purposes of vocations and communities to build a flourishing society. In Grundtvig's view, traditional schools in Denmark were "schools for death," with instruction in Latin and pedagogies detached from the life of the people. Grundtvig promoted, in contrast, "schools for life," grounded most importantly in the experiences and life of common people not the elite. Education for life requires a dynamic community of teachers and students (he proposed they live and work together). It engages the problems of the community and the society as occasions for learning. Folk education also creates settings where different occupations interact, "agricultural workers, large and small independent farmers, skilled manual workers of every trade, sailors and businessmen."[10]

Inspired by folk school traditions and settlement house traditions, Mims spread the view of education for life to public universities and extension work in more than 1000 poor communities in the south and midwest, black and white (an important research question is whether the community organizing tradition extended to Oklahoma). In her view, extension agents should be a "leaven" for community self-organization. "So-called 'social workers' cannot hammer a community into shape," she argued in her widely read book *The Awakening Community.* "If a community grows, it must do so from the inside."[11] This focus gained wide currency in public universities, contending with technocratic and positivist dynamics. "The program of Extension work in agriculture and home economics for 20 years has been based on the policy of personal participation on the part of farm people in the analysis of the economic, social, and other problems and in the carrying out of the solutions to them," wrote Ransom Baldwin, director of Michigan extension system in 1934. "Through these experiences they have discovered and developed their own capacities for learning and leadership. Studying, thinking, and acting together has stimulated growth, nourished initiative, and inspired self-dependence…This development of people themselves, through their own efforts, is the Extension Service's most valuable contribution to society."[12]

Citizen professional agents in extension, like many faculty members and staff, saw their work as "building democracy." Ruby Green Smith, a leader in national and New York home economics, was an eloquent voice for this perspective. She wrote that "there is a vigorous reciprocity in the Extension Service because it is *with* the people, as well as 'of' the people, by the people, and for the people.' It not only carries knowledge from the State Colleges to the people, but it works in reverse." Smith believed that extension work was far richer than problem solving. "In ideal extension work, science and art meet life and practice." She argued eloquently that "it is not enough for people to have food shelter, and clothing…they also aspire to find

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[9] Liberty Hyde Bailey, *Cornell Nature Study Leaflets* (Albany: Lyon, 1904), pp. 52-53; 133; 29-30.

[10] Grundtvig *Selected Writings,* 151, 156-157.

[11] Mims quoted from Scott Peters, *Extension Work as Public Work: Reconsidering Cooperative Extension's Civic Mission,"* Ph.D. dissertation, University of Minnesota, 1997 p. 72. See also Linda Benedict and Randy LaBauve, "The Extraordinary Mary Mims," LSU Ag Center, 2015, http://www.lsuagcenter.com/portals/communications/publications/agmag/archive/2014/spring/the-extraordinary-mary-mims

[12] Rolman J. Baldwin, "Outlook Broadened," *Extension Service Review* Vol. 5, No. 6 (June, 1934), pp. 89, 95.

appreciation, respect for individuality and human dignity, affection, ideals, and opportunities…the satisfactions that belong to democratic living."[13]

All of these themes are evident in Oklahoma extension. Chapter 12 of the OSU Centennial Histories Series, focused on the work of home economists, is full of stories of citizen professionals who were attentive to women's need for agency within families, alert to opportunities for leadership development, politically savvy in advancing their own interests and the public purposes of their work, and adept at affirming multiple kinds of knowledge. Space doesn't permit me to do this justice but let me note one story of many, suggesting what we call, today, transdisciplinary knowledge. "Beginning in 1951, close cooperative relationships between resident (i.e. university faculty) and extension home economics staffs helped strengthen family life in Oklahoma," reads the history. "The resident and extension staffs worked cooperatively on common problems. The extension staff was notified of regular faculty meetings and participated in such meetings as active or consulting meetings of faculty committees."[14]

So, what happened?

The technocratic paradigm

"Neo-liberalism," the spread of marketplace modes of thought and action – as Ben Fink has described, the product of a sophisticated intellectual movement over decades - is seen by many progressives as the culprit for higher education's dilemmas. While recognizing the spread of a market framework beyond its appropriate domains, I want to argue that the problem is not but also incentive structures in research universities and the "cult of the expert," or technocracy.[15]

American Academic Culture in Transformation, a collection of essays by leaders in four disciplines edited by Thomas Bender and Karl Schorske, shows how much academic incentive structures have created a "weakening of the informal compact between the university and society." The rankings wars have also played a role in detachment. The efforts to translate the "democracy college" ideal from land grant and public universities to Syracuse University, led by Chancellor Nancy Cantor from 2004 to 2013, was thwarted by Syracuse's drop in the *US News and World Report* rankings, despite innovations supported by faculty and students and praised across the country.[16]

There is another problem, the philosophy of default positivism which has changed concepts of research, especially in the sciences and social science, and advanced faculty detachment. Scientists of all kinds came to view civic life and other citizens from the outside. "The scientists who powerfully shaped the national discourse on science in the middle years of the twentieth century drew a sharp line between science and society", writes Harvard historian Andrew Jewett in his study, *Science, Democracy, and the American University.* "They portrayed science as utterly deaf to human concerns." [17]

Leaders in higher education in America embody the technocratic stance of outsider unselfconsciously. Thus Donna Shalala, former Chancellor of the University of Wisconsin, later in the Clinton cabinet, now head of the Clinton Foundation, illustrated this dynamic in a famous speech calling for renewal of the Wisconsin Idea in 1989, "Mandate for a New Century." Shalala called for universities to be at the forefront of action on problems such as racism, sexism, homophobia, environmental degradation, hunger and war. She also redefined the older Wisconsin Idea into an unabashedly technocratic perspective. As she put it, "The ideal [is] a disinterested technocratic elite... society's best and brightest in service to its most needy [dedicated to] delivering the miracles of social science…as our research eliminated juvenile rickets in the past." [18] In such a framework the

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[13] Peters, "Forgotten Lineage," pp. 73, 76.
[14] Oklahoma State University Centennial Histories Chapter 12, Extension, pp. 225-226.
[15] See Ben Fink, "Organized Ideas," Ph.D. Dissertation, University of Minnesota, 2015.
[16] See Harry C. Boyte, "Democracy and the Rankings," *Huffington Post,* December 1, 2014.
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[18] Donna Shalala, "Mandate for a New Century" http://www.uic.edu/depts/oaa/ddh/ddhlectures/Lec11.pdf

general population, no longer productive citizens, lose agency entirely, reconceived as needy clients and consumers serviced by experts. Citizenship itself is narrowed to practices like voting, volunteering, or petitioning government for redress. This dynamic is the principle driver for the shrinking of dominant understandings of democracy itself.

Pope Francis' climate encyclical, *Laudato Si'*, helps to illuminate such views. Francis describes the shift that prioritizes informational approaches for dealing with problems over relational and cultural approaches. "The basic problem", he argues in Globalization of the Technocratic Paradigm, "is the way that humanity has taken up...an undifferentiated and one-dimensional paradigm [that] exalts the concept of a subject, who, using logical and rational procedures, progressively approaches and gains control over an external object."[19]

Scholarship and theory in civic engagement parallel Francis' perspective. In 2007 a group including Stephen Elkin, Peter Levine, Jane Mansbridge, Elinor Ostrom, Rogers Smith, Karol Soltan, and myself brought together by the journal of engaged political theory, *The Good Society*, launched civic studies as a transdisciplinary field in part to challenge positivist science and the technocratic stance.[20] Civic studies emphasizes human agency and citizens as co-creators of communities at different scales. Ostrom won the Nobel Prize in Economics for the work she and her husband Vincent, working with an international group of researchers, had done on citizen-centered governance of common pool resources like irrigation systems, forests, and fisheries. Civic studies seeks to reintegrate what the modern world and its theories of knowledge have split apart. It emphasizes that we all are citizens. As Levine puts it, "Scholars [are] citizens, engaged with others in creating [our] worlds...accountable for the actual results of their thoughts and not just the ideas themselves." How can we reintegrate our schools into communities? The answer is citizen professionalism.

Revitalizing the public dimensions of work

Public work, sustained effort by a mix of people who create something, material or culture, of lasting civic value, can be explored through three dimensions of "public": work *for* public purposes; work *in* public; and work *by* "publics." Here's a final slide on citizen professionalism.

	Government-centered	Community-centered	Work-centered
What is democracy?	Free elections	Moral order based on civic responsibility	Way of life built through public work
What is the citizen?	Voter, consumer	Volunteer	Co-creator
What is civic education?	Knowledge of republican institutions	Service learning, public service, community engagement	Public work*
What is professional role?	To provide expert knowledge	To facilitate community	"On tap not on top" -building civic agency, co-creating civic life
Key methods of change?	Expert advice, advocacy, lobbying	Pro-bono work	Civic organizing, capacity building

[19] Pope Francis *Laudato Si'* (Vatican: Vatican Press, 2015), pp. 78-79, 80, 109, 77.

[20] See "What Is Civic Studies?" http://activecitizen.tufts.edu/civic-studies/

Higher education role?	Training experts and providing services	Civic education, character building	Public scholarship, educating citizen professionals (e.g. citizen teachers), colleges as "village commons"

*Public work is visible effort by a mix of people that creates things of lasting civic significance, material and cultural. It integrates the three columns. Chart by Boyte (CDC), Ström (Institute for Democracy in South Africa), Elinor Ostrom (Civic Studies) 2/21/2017

*Work **for** public purposes*

In the United States, the 2016 presidential campaign, for all the differences between Trump and Hillary Clinton, dramatized the narrowing of the meaning of democracy and citizenship. It also illustrated the connections of this narrowing to the evisceration of the public dimensions of work. Clinton was fighting for us as a technocratic expert. Trump was the consummate snake oil salesman from America's past, embodying the idea that "everything is for sale."[21] I often thought about the story of the two bricklayers as we travelled through India. Asked what they were doing, one said building a wall. The other said building a cathedral.

Even asking the question of the purpose in work can be radical in our time, as we discovered in 1997 and 1998 when our Center for Democracy and Citizenship conducted interviews with senior faculty members across the University of Minnesota after the Kellogg Foundation asked us to make an assessment of the possibilities for renewing the public service mission of the university. The UMN, like OSU, is a land grant university. It was once well-known for its extensive involvement with the civic life of Minnesota's communities (even at times called a "democracy college").[22] This identity has sharply eroded.

Edwin Fogelman, chair of the Political Science Department, and I asked several dozen professors if they went into their fields with the desire for public impact. The question surfaced dramatic and hidden discontents. Virtually all began their careers wanting to have public impact. Almost all felt frustrated by the deepening culture of detachment whose norms hold "value neutrality" to be constitutive of scholarly excellence. Many, widely seen as leaders in their fields, told me that they would not be able even to discuss their discontents given the strong biases of research cultures of disciplines against extensive public engagement.[23]

Silence about public purposes in research cultures is part of a wider pattern. As citizenship has been consigned to voting and volunteering, we've lost citizen lawyers, citizen teachers, citizen beauticians, citizen businesspeople. In her book, *The Politics and Civics of National Service,* Melissa Bass shows how changing understandings of national service illustrate the severance of the tie between public purpose and work. For President Franklin Roosevelt, the Civilian Conservation Corps (CCC), a national service effort which enlisted more than three million young men in conservation projects in the 1930s and 1940s, was important because of the connection. The CCC "generated 'moral and spiritual value' to a nation dispirited by crisis and contributed to the 'up-building of a national culture' by bringing together a mix of young men, diverse by the standards of the time." In contrast, when President Kennedy created the National Service Corps thirty years later, he declared work and service programs to be "wholly distinct." "The Youth Employment program," he said, "is designed for those young people who are in need help." In contrast, "the National Service Corps is designed for those citizens of every age, young and old, who wish to be of help."[24]

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[21] Harry C. Boyte, "How Consumer Culture Is Killing Citizenship," BillMoyers.com, August 26, 2016, http://billmoyers.com/story/consumer-culture-killing-citizenship/ .

[22] On this tradition, see Scott Peters, *Democracy and Higher Education* (Michigan State University Press).

[23] See Harry C. Boyte, *Public Engagement in a Civic Mission* (Kettering Foundation, 2000); and Boyte, *Everyday Politics,* Chapter Eight.

[24] Melissa Bass, *Lessons from America's Civilian Conservation Corps* (IDASA: Pretoria, 2003).

We have found that when students in the United States are introduced to the idea of citizen professionalism it awakens a similar spirit. Ali Oosterhuis, an undergraduate at the University of Minnesota who plans a career in socially relevant law, describes the dedication to being a "citizen lawyer," developed through learning skills of political empowerment through the youth initiative Public Achievement and by reading books like Charron's *Freedom's Teacher* and Charles Wilkinson's *Blood Struggle,* on how rights-oriented law was used by American Indians in a decades-long Indian struggle from "termination to self-determination." "My goal over the next few years is to create a concrete mission that I can work toward during my career as a citizen lawyer," says Oosterhuis. "This feat will not be easy. However, I will not give up, just as the Indians refused to give up in the long struggle for their rights. I will use the skills I have learned through Public Achievement, this book, and organizing experiences I have had so far to follow a rich tradition of organizing."[25]

Ali's statement is a generational manifesto. She shows the desire we often see among students for work with public purpose, citizen professionalism. Citizen professionalism depends on breaking out of the silos of narrow ways of knowing and learning to function in what we call free spaces, work *in* public.

*Work **in** public*

The way disciplines and fields are structured and taught separates fields of knowledge from each other. Empirical fields of natural and social sciences are separated from cultural and normative fields. Scientists are supposed to be "objective." Humanities and cultural scholars are concerned with questions of value and meaning but largely critics not actors. Both are separated from professions and professions are usually little concerned with *citizen* capacity to act.[26] As Philip Nyden, co-chair of the American Sociological Association's Task Force on Public Sociology, observes, "Academics may be well trained in methodology and theory, but they are not always trained or experienced in…the political process of bringing about change…[their] 'problem-oriented' approach-- which assumes that the community has a deficit – obscures that fact that *academic researchers themselves may have a deficit* that needs to be corrected by experienced community leaders and activists."[27] Nyden observes that every sociology department has a course called "social problems." He has never heard of one with a course called "social solutions."

Citizen professionals learn to draw from many sources of knowledge, in the tradition of Ruby Green Smith. Complex problems are rarely discrete phenomena around which generic professional interventions can be mounted successfully if one is attentive to overall community well-being. With a focus on public work, not simply "mobilizing" for preset goals, "problems" come to be understood as interconnected – lead poison in housing may be tied to the jobs that require people to live in certain areas, for instance. They are also woven into the life of civic communities. Thus they are different in every community, requiring distinctive approaches that integrates many kinds of knowledge including local cultures with their unique histories, networks, capacities, and identities. Working in public goes against the grain of the way academics and professionals are trained to think of knowledge as a private resource to be horded not shared. A story illustrates the contrasting public work approach.

In Tomah, Wisconsin, in a collaborative project in 1993 and 1994 called Communities Mobilized for Change on Alcohol with the University of Minnesota's department of epidemiology on teenage alcohol use, our Center for Democracy and Citizenship found that a focus on public work transformed technocratic public health practices while developing new approaches to collaboration and public leadership development. We argued with the department of epidemiology's approach for two years. Though they had asked us to help develop an

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[25] Ali Oosterhuis, "Reflection on Blood Struggle," November 27, 2016, Independent study with Boyte.

[26] See Peter Levine, "The Case for Civic Studies," in Peter Levine and Karol Soltan, Eds., *Civic Studies* (Washington: AAC&U/Bringing Theory to Practice, 2014).

[27] Philip Nyden "Public Sociology, Engaged Research, and Civic Education," in *Civic Studies,* p. 109.

"organizing" approach, in fact they wanted to "mobilize." That is, they wanted to use techniques to rally eight communities in Minnesota and Wisconsin around a preset objective – having local city governments adopt stringent penalties for stores that sold alcohol to underage drinkers. This is the customary approach of public health, in which "evidence-based interventions" focus on predetermined policies and behavior change to deal with a particular health problem. We argued for "civic organizing," based on the idea the one cannot predetermine solutions. To develop empowering strategies requires involving diverse groups and engaging many kinds of knowledge.

To accomplish this shift, Jeanne Carls, the organizer in Tomah, Wisconsin, created a strategy team with diverse groups and interests who had never worked together, and did not agree on the definition of "the problem." Yet all agreed that something was wrong after several teenage deaths in alcohol related incidents. Police, bar owners, merchants, church leaders, teenagers, parents, and public health professionals became involved. "You tell people that there are going to be many different people coming together who you may have thought would never be at the same table, but can see the need to work on the same issue," Carls recounted. "It was like bringing lions to the table. People would sit across the table and never talk to each other directly, but they all had an interest in youth, and in Tomah." Health care workers, city officials, and lay citizens worked to define what "the problem" entailed.

A view of teenage alcohol use as woven into the particular civic culture of Tomah emerged. The team came to realize that the annual festival, in which beer drinking was the central ritual for people of all ages, was both a symbol and wellspring of the town's drinking culture. All were responsible for the "problem," understood in this fashion. And many different groups were required to change it. Such a change also entailed a shift in professional practices from one-way policy interventions to collaborative public work. "I bring some specific skills and knowledge, like how things are decided in city politics," said Dave Berner, the city manager. "But many others make contributions as well." Work on teen alcohol abuse resulted in Berner and others professionals in the city rethinking their jobs in more public ways. It also created publics.

*Work **by** publics*

People are not born knowing how to work in publics, with people who make them uncomfortable, whom they disagree with or may dislike intensely. Learning the skills of work with people who are very different involves a citizen politics, politics that revolves around citizens not politicians. It requires spaces where such politics is learned. In the United States free spaces abounded. They schooled the general population in a larger civic identity and the skills to act on it. They generated citizen professionals who see themselves as "citizens first," and knew how to interact with different kinds of people. They helped to create" publics."

Politicians today, across societies, generally prefer approaches which mobilize people against their opponents.[28] But there are strong, if submerged, traditions of government and political leadership taking a different role, as empowering partner and convener for collaborative public work.[29] James Kloppenberg's *Virtues of Liberalism,* Lisbeth Cohen's *Making a New Deal,* and Jess Gilbert's *Planning Democracy: Agrarian Intellectuals and the Intended New Deal,* richly describe these currents in the 1930s.

Interaction between popular movements of the Great Depression and government sometimes generated large scale examples of government working in collaborative ways that helped to "create publics." I call this the model of government as *empowering partners,* neither savior nor enemy.

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[28] Jayati Ghosh, "India's Rural Employment Program Is Dying a Death of Funding Cuts," *The Guardian,* February 5, 2015.
[29] This is taken from Harry Boyte, "Democratic Awakening," BillMoyers.Com, October 14, 2016.

From 1938 to 1941 a group of agrarian leaders in the Department of Agriculture worked with land grant colleges like OSU, cooperative extension workers, and community leaders to develop an initiative on rural America. “They believed that democracy required continuous learning, personal growth, cultural adjustment, and civic discussion,” writes Gilbert. The effort involved farm organizations and unions, churches, youth clubs, professional and business groups, and government agencies, training about 60,000 discussion leaders. It involved three million people. It conveyed the idea that democracy is something people make together and launched a process of participatory land use planning across the country that helped to birth soil conservation districts, prevention of soil erosion, fertility depletion and protection of family farms.

The rural initiative created precedents for government initiative like the programs of the Department of Housing and Urban Development during the president of Jimmy Carter, organized by Geno Baroni, who served as director of the Office of Neighborhood Self Help in the years. In recent years a view of government as empowering partner has been returning. Carmen Sirianni’s *Investing in Democracy* details examples. Each June the Frontiers of Democracy conference sponsored by the Civic Studies Institute and Tufts University’s Tisch College of Civic Life includes many examples from around the world. These point to a challenge which is emerging to the “citizen as customer” model of government practice, and also to practices and views of politics as simply polarizing.

The work of professionals affiliated with the Citizen Professional Center – Bill Doherty, Tai Mendenhall, Jerica Berge, Shonda Craft, and others – shows what this approach can look like both inside and outside of government. The Citizen Professional Center was founded by Doherty, a leading family therapist and professor at the University of Minnesota. Doherty and his colleagues developed the public work framework in family and health professions, based on the idea that the energy and talent of families and communities are the most important resource for addressing complex problems. Citizen professionals are catalysts and organizers who work *with* lay citizens, not *on* them or *for* them. Over the years the Center created partnerships with a wide variety of communities and groups, including middle class families worried about the erosion of family life in a hyper-competitive, individualist culture where “activities” crowd out relationships; American Indians in the Twin Cities, who have led in the creation of a campaign for abatement of diabetes, combining traditional native healing practices with scientific medicine, African American fathers fighting cultural messages which degrade fatherhood, and many others; and Hennepin County in Minnesota, reorienting their professionals as “citizen professionals” who do not have the answer to complex problems. In every case, their work has combined on the ground development of civic skills and leadership with high level “cultural organizing,” finding ways to frame concerns which resonate widely with Americans who are concerned about increasing materialism, consumerism, and individualism. Their work has received widespread visibility and publicity from major news outlets like the *New York Times, USA Today* and the networks. “For me the key starting point is to ask professionals to think about their work as a contribution to the capacity for democratic living,” Doherty told me.

Finally, the nonviolent approach in the freedom movement which shaped me as a young man is a resource for citizen professionals involved in the work of building publics. Nonviolence in the movement was never simply a strategy and tactics nor was it “pacifism,” refusal to use physical force under any circumstances. Nonviolence was a philosophy involving a set of spiritual, moral and psychological disciplines that refuse to *demonize* opponents. In *Stride Toward Freedom,* Martin Luther King’s book about the Montgomery bus boycott which made nonviolence famous in the civil rights movement, King outlines spiritual disciplines all revolving around including the decision to undertake the hard work of “love” in a public, intentional way. Such public love involves nonviolence as struggle, not inaction; seeking to understand opponents, not to defeat or humiliate them; making distinctions between evil actions and the persons who commit the actions; “neighborly concern for others,” whether friend or enemy, recognizing their “need for belonging to the best in the human family”; and focus on first changing oneself by refraining from hatred. “Hate…corrodes the personality and eats away at its vital unity,” King wrote. “The nonviolent approach…first

does something to the hearts and souls of those committed to it. It gives them new self-respect. It calls up resources of strength and courage they did not know they had." [30]

These principles have kinship with what Alain de Botton, the philosopher, calls "the hard work of love." He distinguishes between private love and public love. "A functioning society requires…love and politeness. By 'love' I mean a capacity to enter imaginatively into the minds of people with whom you don't immediately agree and to look for more charitable explanations for behavior which doesn't appeal to you and which could seem plain wrong." Today, he adds, "all sides are attempting to show how stupid every other side is."[31]

"The hard work of love" contributes to the theory of "relational power," not simply one way power. The idea of relational power recognizes that interactions, even in situations of inequality, always involve changes on both sides. They are interactive and evolving. And relational power dynamics can generate more power, not "power over," or even "power with" but also "power to," the capacity to act. The question of relational power and public relationships is relevant for every profession. Other signs of citizen professionalism point to reinvigoration of schools, congregations, businesses, unions, and health clinics, and cultural groups as civic sites and free spaces. At Augsburg, both the nursing and education departments have missions to prepare their students to be change agents – citizen nurses and citizen teachers.

It will take a substantial movement building on such examples to challenge disempowering views of democracy, citizenship, and politics. This requires revitalizing the civic narratives of institutions, creating "new" social capital, not simply activating remaining pockets of social capital, as is the usual strategy even among the best civic groups. It also means reviving the model of government as partner, not savior or enemy. I think we need a bipartisan effort to do this, something like a 21st century nonpartisan caucus of citizen legislators in both parties.[32]

Finally, need also to remember the deeper meanings of democracy in our history – a task for which professionals and land grant institutions are well positioned. This is a new frontier of democracy, recalling Walt Whitman's *Democratic Vistas*

> *Did you, O friend, suppose democracy was only for elections…for a party name? I say democracy is only of use there that it may pass on and come to its flower and fruits in manners, in the highest forms of interaction…in religion, literature, colleges and schools…I submit that the fruition of democracy, on ought like a grand scale, resides altogether in the future.*

[30] From Harry C. Boyte and Marie-Louise Ström, "Nonviolent Civic Life Worksheet," January 24, 2017.
[31] Alain De Botton, "The True Hard Work of Love and Relationships," Krista Tippett, "On Being," February 9, 2017, transcript.
[32] Archon Fung, "Can Social Movements Save Democracy?" *Boston Review,* February 1, 2003.